

the first corner after finding himself among four cars who entered Turn 1 abreast with each other.

Lap six saw another trip across the turf after the Dutchman made contact with Lewis Hamilton. A tyre lock-up forced the latter to eventually concede position before he too cut across the tarmac. **The advantage earned came at a cost, though, as the seven-time champion was slapped with a 10-second penalty, which relegated him to eighth after a season-best third-place start.**

The melee helped Haas's Oliver Bearman scythe through the pack. A combination of Hamilton's penalty, Piastri's lack of pace, and the two Mercedes' overheating issues helped the 20-year-old end up fourth — his career-best finish in F1. Esteban Ocon's ninth place helped the American outfit earn a double-points finish for the fifth time this year, keeping its fight for sixth in the Teams' Championship well and truly alive.

Verstappen made a late attempt to wrest second place from Leclerc on the penultimate lap of the race but was thwarted after Carlos Sainz's stall at the side of the track triggered the deployment of the Virtual Safety Car. The Williams driver had parked his car close to the marshal posts to aid quick retrieval, but the VSC neutralised the racing and Verstappen's hopes of cutting the points deficit.

Four races remain this season. One point separates the top two in the Drivers' Championship and also second and third in the Constructors' standings. Just as Verstappen seemed to have the momentum, Norris displayed a glimpse of why McLaren is still the best car on the grid. **The fast-paced, undulating Sao Paulo track is up next for the F1 bandwagon.** The flowing track promises a lot of overtaking action through the race, and Red Bull will know that tuning the car for one-lap superiority might not cut it for its star driver's championship hopes.



Back in form: Just as Max Verstappen seemed to have the momentum, Lando Norris displayed a glimpse of why McLaren is still the best car (in pic) on the grid. With four races remaining this season, only one point separates the top two in the Drivers' Championship. REUTERS

MotoGP



It was a bittersweet weekend for the Marquez family during the Malaysian Grand Prix. Marc, the 2025 World Champion, missed out on participation following surgery on his broken shoulder, adding to his spate of injuries since his last championship win in 2019.

In his absence, younger brother Alex (**right**) brought home the smiles, securing second place in the Sprint Race to seal the runner-up spot in the riders' standings. **It is the first time in MotoGP history that a pair of brothers have finished first and second in the championship.**

Gresini Ducati rider Alex celebrated the achievement with a commanding win in the main race in Sepang, his third win of the calendar year. Double World Champion Francesco Bagnaia enjoyed a silver lining in a largely frustrating season with a Sprint victory, but his joy was cut short on Sunday when mechanical issues forced him to miss out on a place on the podium.

Pedro Acosta finished second in the race, his fourth podium for the KTM factory team this season. Former World Champion Joan Mir of Honda rounded out the podium with his second top-three finish in four races.



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